

Ottoboni, the last in a controversial line of cardinal-nephews appointed by the pope, treated Corelli as a friend, as evident in his letters to the composer.

Ingenuity and originality

The ample orchestras belonging to the two cardinals served as musical laboratories for Corelli. He used them to test his concertos for strings. These were strikingly inventive works that influenced other musicians in Rome, including Handel, and traveled beyond the Alps after Corelli signed a publishing deal with Estienne Roger of Amsterdam in 1712. Bach and Tartini were among those who based original compositions on themes by Corelli, a trend that was revived in the 20th century by Rachmaninoff and Tippett.

Corelli's Op. 6 collection, published in 1714, a year after his death, contains 12 concerti grossi: eight in the so-called church style, four in the chamber style. Europe's music-lovers were captivated by their ingenuity—not least the lilting Largo from Op. 6, No. 8, the “Christmas Concerto”—and by the great economy and ease of Corelli's writing. His six publications went through multiple editions and remained in the repertoire throughout the 18th century, rare in an age that was hungry for the latest fashions.